of my dreams (unless you count a four-year-old's aspirations to become a fireman).

My dad had negotiated a deal with Mr. Pitney under which he became part owner of the Fashion Boot Shop in exchange for his management of it. For a long time while we were growing up, it was assumed by everyone in the family that as soon as we got out of high school, Neil and I would go to work at the store and when Jack was ready to retire, we'd take it over.

From time to time, I helped out at the store, but found it boring; besides, those books I'd read about college life had given me my own ideas about the future.

With their casts of characters drawn from rich old Eastern families, the glamorous Ivy League life depicted in the stories was admittedly pretty remote from the reality of my life as a towheaded kid in overalls from a poor family in rural Illinois.

But I read and reread the stories and I began to dream of myself on a college campus, wearing a college jersey, even as a *star* on the football team. My childhood dream was to become like those guys in the books.

All my heroes weren't college football stars. A wonderful book about a devout itinerant Christian—*That Printer of Udell's*—made such an impact on me I decided to join my mother's church, the Disciples of Christ. Although Jack and Nelle were married by a Catholic priest, Nelle assumed responsibility for the spiritual preparation of my brother and me. She first took us to Sunday school, then, when we were older, to the main services, but always said she'd leave it up to us to decide whether we wanted to actually join the church. At twelve, I made my decision and was baptized as a member of the Disciples of Christ.

When Nelle thought Neil and I were old enough to know, she sat us down and explained why my father sometimes